

The Utility of User Scripts (JS) and User Styles (CSS)

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The browsing experience can be marred by a few irritants. A ticked box asking users to remain signed in, a poor choice of colours for the Web page, or pages asking for your phone number before signing you in... all these things can be done away with through the judicious use of user scripts and user styles.

JavaScript and CSS are not just server-end technologies. You can write your own scripts and style sheets, and make your Web browser apply them to any website. In this article, we will breeze through this esoteric form of JavaScript and CSS, and learn why it has thousands of loyal fans, many of whom have not even written a single line of JavaScript or CSS, and yet swear that their browsing method is a cut above the rest.

How many times have you wished that some websites had chosen different colours, contrasts or font sizes? Have you wished some websites did not make intolerable demands on your patience or try to make you feel vulnerable? Well... user styles and scripts can help. They can make recalcitrant websites behave and good websites become better. Finally, you will be in control.

User scripts and user styles are supposed to be written by end-users (we, the ones using the browser) to customise the functionality or the look-and-feel of websites they visit. This

is quite contrary to the popular perception that CSS and JavaScript files are authored by Web designers and are part of the websites they originate from.

While it may seem that knowledge of CSS and JavaScript is a prerequisite, most fans simply visit websites such as OpenUserJS.org or UserStyles.org to get what they want. Just like bookmarks, thousands of user JS and user CSS, for almost every imaginable purpose, have been published. I write almost all of my user scripts/styles. If you are a Web developer, you might want to do the same.

In the Firefox, Seamonkey and IceApe browsers, you can use the Greasemonkey add-on to manage and execute user scripts, and the Stylish add-on to manage and apply user styles. Both add-ons provide a text editor to write your JS/CSS. The add-ons also let you apply the CSS/JS to a specific site (using wildcards in URLs) or to all sites, in general.